

UTT Chapter 15 Assignment

Hello there!

Sorry I haven't written in a while. I thought classes would slow down after midterms. Boy, was I wrong! Student Government elections are coming up in a few weeks, so the gang and I have been making flyers and planning speeches for the debates between the candidates. I can't believe I am actually running for a senate position! I have already been passing out flyers in my classes, and I even gave a speech in front of my Political Theory class about my platform: campus-wide free speech zone, increasing dining hall hours, and a library that is open 24/7. So far, other students have seemed really interested in these policy changes, and others people have actually suggested more of them! I am excited and all, but it is a bit weird seeing my face on flyers around campus. I'll let you know more about what happens in the next few weeks!

Other than campaigning, I haven't been doing too much outside of school. Mark and I have been running in the morning consistently. I don't want to put on the freshman forty! It has been a good experience getting to know Mark better. We have been talking a lot about the elections on campus and all the changes students have been promoting. Through our talks, I began to think seriously about what I was running for and what effects my changes would have at the university. To be honest, I never really paid too much attention during elections at home. It seemed like whoever spent the most money on their campaign won, regardless of their platform. Now, I have an appreciation for politics that I didn't have before. One person can make a difference, and it is important to stand for the right things in life.

Anyway, Mark brought up some interesting ideas about politics. As a Marxist, he spoke rather harshly about the "democracy" of capitalists. He said communism is "true" democracy. Since Sarah and Mark tend to agree, I wonder what she would say in comparison with Mark. **What is the Secularist view of politics? Also how does Marxism view politics?** I am meeting with Paige later on this week to talk about campaign strategies, so I will probably learn more about her views on politics as well. Of course, I would like to be prepared to ask questions. **What role does politics play in Postmodernism?** I know from your last letter that Islam adheres to shariah law. I bet this has implications on their political views, but I am not sure how exactly. **What is the Islamic view of politics?**

During my conversations, I began wondering what Christianity thinks about politics. Growing up, I heard people say Christians shouldn't be involved in politics because the world is a lost cause. Mark seems to agree. He said Christians should to stick to the immaterial world and keep religion out of politics. What do you think? **Should Christians be involved in politics and, if so, how?**

Thanks for all your help! Your worldview class has helped me out a lot. Hopefully we can talk more soon.

See you later!

-Doug

Doug brought up five different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is the Secularist view of politics?

Secularism's political views reflect **progressivism**—the belief that political systems can be used to create economic prosperity, minimize risk, and advance society. It is framed by prior commitments to atheism, naturalism, and materialism. As Secularists see it, the government doesn't just protect our individual rights; it creates human rights. Moreover, humanity isn't fallen; it is perfectible. As human beings evolve, our notions of morality, rights, and the ideal society progress as well. Secularists believe that human beings can, and should, use the government to create a better society. To this end, they tend to favor a strong centralized government, the redistribution of wealth, and a progressive morality (e.g. same-sex marriage and abortion on demand). A number of Secularists even believe that humanity will eventually create a global government championing such ideals. [15.3]

2. How does Marxism view politics?

Marxism takes the idea of progressivism and utopianism even further than Secularism. The ultimate goal of Marxism is communism—a utopian society, devoid of economic status, private property, even government. However, before communism can be obtained, Marx noted the need for a proletariat revolution. After the working class has overthrown capitalism, a Marxist dictatorship will be instated. This Marxist government will institute **statism**—a political system in which a highly centralized government holds the concentration of economic controls and planning. Furthermore, the dictator will silence those who oppose him and help guide society toward a communist civilization. Marxists believe this transition is inevitable, not just for a few countries but for the entire world. [15.4]

3. What role does politics play in Postmodernism?

Postmodern politics manifests itself in two branches: **political pessimism** (a general distrust for any political system's ability to alleviate social problems) and **progressivism**. Because Postmodernists operate under the assumption that reality is not directly accessible, many view politics as a means for gaining power to promote the tenets of a particular worldview at the expense of others. Anti-political Postmodernists see the critique of politics as the best solution for the predicament of politics—politics can't improve society; it can only reflect the assumptions of those in charge.

Progressive Postmodernists tend to promote more liberal political ideas: big government, redistribution of wealth, and a secular view morality. A key postmodern political concept is **identity politics**. Through identity politics, Postmodernists seek to advance the interests of particular social groups that

they believe have been marginalized by society (e.g. women, minorities, and homosexuals). One practical application of identity politics can be seen in political correctness training—the censoring of language, actions, and policies that are believed to alienate particular groups. [15.5]

4. What is the Islamic view of politics?

Islam doesn't separate religion and government. The Islamic political ideal is an **Islamic theocracy**—a state ruled by Islam and Islamic religious leaders based upon the principles of shariah law. Religious pluralism doesn't exist in an Islamic state. In many Islamic countries, Jews and Christians (referred to as *dhimmi*) are often persecuted. *Dhimmi* are usually allowed to live in Islamic countries, but the Quran requires that they pay a tax called *jizya* to show submission to Islam. For many Muslims, the ultimate political goal is a global Islamic state. And the method for achieving this goal is through jihad. Although some Muslims contend that jihad is purely defensive, both the history of Islam and the Quran seem to disagree. [15.7]

5. Should Christians be involved in politics and if so, how?

Due to the brokenness of man, Christianity recognizes that the government's primary mission is to preserve justice and punish evil. The government is an institution established by God to promote security and justice, protect the innocent, and secure the rights granted by God so that human beings have the opportunity to flourish. Because God ordained it, government is a sacred institution, and its rulers are supposed to be his ministers of good. Part of this good is the recognition that decisions are best handled at the organizational or societal level closest to the issues or persons affected. This concept is called **subsidiarity**. Christians uniquely understand the fallen nature of mankind, the tendency of power to corrupt, and the limitations God placed on the state. They also uniquely understand the negative consequences that result from a government run by individuals who don't understand the government's role and limitations. It is therefore the responsibility of Christians to be engaged in politics. Government cannot solve all of society's problems, but when it functions properly, it can be a valuable part of a thriving society. [15.8]